Questions to Ask the Discharge Planner, the Care Team and the Business Office Before Mom Leaves

Fifteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

The discharge planner stops by Mom's room and asks if you have any questions, and your mind goes blank. Bring these written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one, with the name of the person who gave it.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on Mom, and the people below are the ones who know her situation.

The discharge planner or social worker

The person arranging what happens after this stay. It may be a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff.

1. What is the expected discharge date, and what has to happen before it?
2. What care does the team expect Mom to need after she leaves here?
3. Where could that care be provided, at home with help or somewhere else, and who helps us look at the options?
4. Can we have the discharge plan and any instructions in writing?
5. Who do we call with questions once she has left?

The doctor

1. What level of care do you think Mom needs right now, and what is that based on?
2. What do you still need to see before you can say what she will need next?

The nurses and therapists

1. What does Mom do for herself here, and what do the staff help her with: bathing, dressing, eating, using the toilet, getting in and out of bed, walking?

2. What have you noticed about her memory, and about how she manages when no one is with her?

3. Which medications were started, stopped or changed during this stay, and who will go over the list with us before she leaves?

4. Is any equipment being recommended, and who arranges it?

The business office

The office at the hospital or facility that handles billing. If you aren't sure who that is, ask the social worker.

1. Is Medicare covering Mom's care here at the moment?

2. Is that coverage expected to change, and if it is, how and when will we be told?

3. If it changes, what would our family be asked to pay for, and who do we talk to about it?

Your Medicaid planner

Someone who helps a family put the whole picture in one place and line up its questions about levels of care, coverage and cost.

1. Here is what we've written down and what we've been told so far. What else should we ask the facility and the care team before the next decision?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or tell you which one comes first. If something worries you, say so to the person in front of you. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and soon some answers. The care interview gives those answers a place to go: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns what you tell it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to the discharge planner, the care team or your Medicaid planner.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Several of these questions follow the ones the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide and Medicare.gov suggest families ask. The grouping by role is ours.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage